

WATER VIEW
Asian Paints reimagined 40 shikaras; Arjun Bahl with Amit Syngle

PARADISE REIMAGINED

In a brilliant confluence of heritage and contemporary design, Asian Paints and St+art Foundation transform Dal Lake into a living, moving canvas of the Valley's soul

Bureau Report

In a brilliant cultural coup, Asian Paints has teamed up with the St+art Foundation and XXL Collective to unleash Aks-e-Kashmir, a stunning public art takeover that transforms forty iconic shikaras into floating, high-design masterworks. Far from just a fresh coat of gloss, this initiative, alongside a monumental tenth-anniversary 'Donate A Wall' mural at the University of Kashmir, proves that tradition doesn't have to be static. "From celebrating Kolkata's iconic yellow taxis as moving symbols of the city's spirit to the shikaras that have created experiences inspired by the colours, culture and heritage of Kashmir. This tribute continues that journey," says Amit Syngle, Managing Director and CEO, Asian Paints.

The Moving Canvas

By treating shikaras as floating canvases, the project elevates everyday



craft into the realm of high design. Four contemporary artists, Owais Ahmed, Sheehij Kaul, Zahra Javed and Shweta Sharma, were commissioned to anchor this transformation. Each artist brings a distinct narrative voice to the water by leaning into the valley's distinct identities, creating a fluid dialogue between the boat, the water and the spectator.

Symphony of Paint and Shimmer

From a design perspective, the execution of Aks-e-Kashmir is a technical triumph over difficult terrain. The artists utilised Asian Paints Royale Glitz to provide a luxurious, ultra-clean finish that serves as the foundation for the complex artwork. To capture the mercurial personality of Dal Lake, Apcolite Premium Enamel was introduced. Further, honouring the region's legendary woodworking, the handcrafted wooden canopies and structural frames are treated with the nuanced palette of Asian Paints Wood Finish, grounding the vibrant pigments in native, earthy textures.

Immersive Interiors

Step inside any of the 40 reimagined shikaras and the transition from public art to intimate interior sanctuary is seamless. Using Ador and Pure Royale fabrics, the design team crafted bespoke upholstery and furnishings to match the exterior artwork of each individual boat. The result is a highly tactile, immersive environment.